Thesis Plan

Performance, Safety, and Engineering Trade-offs of Rust and C++ in Nokia RAN Control-Plane Systems

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1 Background and motivation

Modern RAN control-plane software (the L3 of a gNB, e.g. the gNB-CU-CP [1]) is written mostly in C++, which delivers the throughput and latency such systems need but carries well-known memory-safety and concurrency risks (use-after-free, data races, double-free). These classes dominate real defect populations, and migrating to memory-safe languages is now an explicit policy position [2, 3]. Rust offers comparable performance with safety guaranteed at compile time on machine-checked foundations [4].

Its fit for latency-critical telecom control planes is unproven. The "Rust performs like C++" consensus rests on general-purpose benchmarks [5] that report average-case behaviour; closer studies find real costs, both in networking code [6] and in specific mechanisms such as bounds and overflow checking [7]. For a RAN control plane the operative metric is not the average but the tail [8]. This thesis is carried out at Nokia on a subsystem modelled on a real Nokia gNB-CU-CP component.

The decision has a long horizon. 3GPP has allocated Release 20 to the 6G studies and Release 21 to the normative work, with full specifications due to the ITU by mid-2030 and migration from 5G explicitly in scope [9, 10], so a language chosen for the control plane of the current generation is inherited by the next.

2 Research gap

Two master's theses at Ericsson are the closest prior work. Karlbäck and Orö compare Rust and Go against C++ for RAN applications and conclude C++ remains the choice where performance is critical [11]. Arvidsson and Kaller measure median and 99th-percentile latency for 5G control-plane procedures across five asynchronous frameworks. C++ with Boost.Fibers is fastest at every load; the Rust runtimes track the shape of its median curve, but their p99 rises more steeply past a threshold rate [12].

Neither isolates the language: in both, the runtime and concurrency model vary together with it, so a measured difference cannot be attributed to the language rather than to the framework built on it. The gap is therefore a comparison that holds the specification, algorithms, concurrency model, allocator, and build settings fixed, *and* sweeps past the saturation knee, *and* measures what incremental migration costs.

3 Objective and research questions

The thesis builds two functionally equivalent implementations of a UE Context Management service in modern C++ and in Rust and compares them under a spec-justified synthetic sig-

nalling workload. Since similar average throughput is already known, it targets four less-explored dimensions:

RQ1 How do Rust and C++ compare in latency predictability (median, p99, p99.9, maximum) under increasing load and overload, with the concurrency model held fixed?

RQ2 Which classes of C++ memory and concurrency defects does safe Rust eliminate at compile time, at what stage are the rest detected, and which classes does it *not* prevent?

RQ3 What overhead, if any, does Rust's safety model impose on throughput, CPU, and memory?

RQ4 What are the practical implications (effort, FFI interoperability, risk) of adopting Rust incrementally in an existing C++ RAN codebase?

RQ2 is deliberately two-sided: a catalogue containing only defects Rust prevents would confirm its own premise, so it spans the boundary: five classes safe Rust rejects and five it does not. Memory-safety defects in real Rust code invariably trace back to `unsafe` [13], while deadlock remains an open problem for the language [14]. Two of the five boundary classes returned the opposite of the expected result, with the C++ tooling reporting what Rust's does not, which is the kind of finding a one-sided catalogue could not have produced.

4 Methodology

A single language-agnostic specification (public API, UE state machine, data structures, sharding and concurrency model) is frozen before any implementation code is written, so the comparison measures language rather than design differences. Both implementations use identical algorithms, a shared-nothing sharded worker-thread model, the same allocator, and comparable build optimisation. Holding the concurrency model fixed matters because thread-per-core structuring itself changes tail latency [15]. Both must pass the same parity suite, whose expected results come from an independent third implementation of the specification rather than from either language, so that agreement between the two cannot be mistaken for correctness of both.

The workload is swept from nominal load to overload on pinned cores, with interleaved repeats and interval estimates rather than single figures [16]: medians with nonparametric bootstrap confidence intervals [17], and exact paired permutation tests corrected across the family by the Holm procedure [18]. Frequency locking belongs to the bare-metal protocol; the virtualised host measured so far does not expose the governor from inside the guest. Latency is captured in high-dynamic-range histograms against an intended send schedule, so coordinated omission does not hide the tail [19, 20]. Evaluation adds a controlled fault-injection study [21] and an FFI prototype. On the FFI, the plan takes a narrow position: confining `unsafe` to the seam is a statement about what the compiler checks, not run-time protection, since host and component share an address space [22]. Only synthetic data is used, so no personal or confidential data is processed.

5 Expected contributions

- A reproducible, telecom-relevant benchmarking framework.
- A frozen shared specification and two parity-tested implementations.
- A quantitative comparison emphasising tail latency under overload.
- A defect-class taxonomy mapping both what the compile-time guarantee covers and where it stops.
- Evidence-based guidelines for incremental Rust adoption, where the dominant cost is the learning curve rather than run-time [23].

6 Status and timeline

Work is well under way. The shared specification, both implementations, the conformance suite, the fault-injection catalogue, the FFI prototype, and the benchmark harness are in place. Chapter drafts and a supervisor-read-through skeleton (`Thesis_v1.tex`) exist. What remains is the bare-metal measurement campaign (RQ1/RQ3 tail claims), final chapter prose for Design through Conclusion, and submission.

Item	State
Literature review	Drafted in thesis skeleton
Spec + implementations	Complete; awaiting supervisor freeze
RQ2 (fault injection)	Complete
RQ4 (FFI prototype)	Complete
RQ1 / RQ3 (benchmarks)	Measured on a dedicated virtualised Xeon host; bare-metal pending for the far tail
Thesis document	In progress (full draft + bullet skeleton)

Month (2026)	Goal	What happens
June	Foundations	Done: topic defined; C++/Rust/5G foundations; literature review drafted.
July	Draft	Done: thesis plan approved; chapter skeleton and evaluation design outlined.
August	Build	In progress: specification and both implementations built; parity suite and benchmark harness operational; bare-metal campaign next.
September	Measure	Provision a bare-metal testbed; run the full campaign; generate figures and numbers.
October	Resolve	Finalise RQ1/RQ3 analysis; confirm or retract the tail claim; revise affected chapters; draft to supervisors and Nokia instructors.
November	Submit	Final revisions, colloquium presentation, submission.

Risks. If the testbed is delayed, RQ1 and RQ3 may remain preliminary; a cloud bare-metal instance or a Nokia lab host is the fallback. If the tail difference proves unresolvable even on bare metal, it is reported as a bounded null result with the confidence interval stated, which is a legitimate finding. Single-author skill asymmetry is bounded by the frozen specification and parity suite, and acknowledged as residual for performance.

Out of scope. The full gNB, PHY/L2 and the user plane, real captured traces, managed-language alternatives, and production operational concerns.

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